polarisation. In the "Cultural Conundrum" session, Ray said that Hindutva can never take root in the Bengali cultural ethos of Rabindranath Tagore, Raja Rammohun Roy and Swami Vivekananda. This prompted Kanchan Gupta, senior adviser, Union ministry of information and broadcasting, to remind him that the idea of Hindutva was first crystallised in Bengal and the first concept of 'Bharat Mata' emerged here, in a painting by the artist Abanindranath Tagore. While Ray argued that the concept of Hindu rashtra, propounded by Savarkar was exclusionary, Gupta countered that the "civilisational concept of nation is always inclusive".

"Accept it or not, polarisation is a harsh reality in Indian politics," said Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP, Sushmita Deb, during the "Driving Force: Performance versus Polarisation" session. Even though she sees nothing wrong in 'social engineering' (a term that has become a shorthand for caste equations) being an accepted part of electoral politics, Deb warned that polarisation brings a dangerous twist to identity-based electoral politics.



"Our new digital venture India Today NE, will showcase the area better and correct misunderstandings about the region"

KALLI PURIE
Vice-chairperson, India Today Group

Pradyot Bikram Manikya Deb Barma, chairman of TIPRA (The Indigenous Progressive Regional Alliance) couldn't agree more. "If performance had mattered, Atal Behari Vajpayee's BJP would have won with the 'India Shining' campaign. But it was only after the BJP campaigned with *ghar ke andar ghus ke maara* (hit them in their homes) that it won a resounding victory." When BJP MLA R.K. Imo Singh tried to reason that development and consistent performance in the Northeast by the current NDA government have secured the support of 'eight sisters' for the BJP, Pradyut said that development by the NDA comes armed with politics: "Why is the Inner Line Permit being allowed in those states which do not share an international boundary with Bangladesh? Is this not pick and choose to secure your vote-bank?" Pradyut argued.

Meghalaya chief minister Conrad Sangma, speaking in the "Regional Realignment" session, gave out the secret of the perfect balancing job that he has mastered. "As there's no need to hide that we are working with

INTERVIEW



"I HAVE SEEN MANY GOVERNMENTS BUT NEVER SUCH A VINDICTIVE ONE"

In a freewheeling discussion with **Rajdeep Sardesai** *at the fifth edition of India Today Conclave East, West Bengal chief minister* **Mamata Banerjee** *not only gave bold brush strokes of what an Opposition leader needs to do for a BJP-mukt Bharat, she also warned Amit Shah that any Maharashtra like adventure in Bengal might cost him dearly*